



Dimensions of fit between a brand and a social cause and their influence on attitudes

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ARTICLE INFO

Article history:

First received in 12, November 2008 and was under review for 5½ months

Area Editor: Zeynep Gurhan-Canli

Keywords:

Fit
Sponsorship fit
Social cause-marketing
Multidimensional construct
Sponsorship attitude
Brand attitude

ABSTRACT

This paper examines cause-marketing promotions and finds that *fit* between social causes and consumer brands can be decomposed into ten “micro” sub-dimensions or two “macro” sub-dimensions (*prominence* and *marketing strategy*) of *fit*. Results indicate *fit* sub-dimensions are significantly related to the attitude toward the sponsorship and the brand, and that attitude toward sponsorship mediates the relationship between *fit* and attitude toward the brand. As such, managers should not only rely on natural *fit* between cause and brand, but they should also attempt to communicate *fit* to the consumers. Importantly, familiarity with the cause interacts with *fit* when attitudes toward the sponsorship and the brand are measured, such that *fit* matters less to those who are more familiar with the cause.

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One only has to walk down the street or take a drive on any road to be exposed to countless social cause-related messages. These messages come in a multitude of forms, shapes, and colors. They range from wristbands and t-shirts to automobile ribbons and bumper stickers. Consumers display their enthusiasm for various social causes both because they believe their actions can influence others to join in supporting their cause and to show others they are good citizens behaving both ethically and compassionately. Such consumer involvement with different social causes has not escaped the eyes of the corporate world. On the contrary, it has sparked great interest in the minds of executives who have realized that aligning their brand with a “good cause” is not only socially responsible but also potentially profitable. This revelation is a direct product of consumers’ acceptance that cause-marketing is a good way to support meaningful causes and consumers’ favorable attitudes toward the sponsoring brands that are involved in such behavior (Ellen, Mohr, & Webb, 2000; Ross, Patterson, & Stutts, 1992).

Alliances between a brand and a social cause that trigger positive attitudes toward the sponsoring brand may be an effective marketing strategy, leading to both increased sales and brand loyalty, both of which could potentially generate a sustainable competitive advantage. However, not all brand–cause relationships result in a positive

outcome for the brand. It has been suggested that, when there is congruence between the brand and the cause, consumers are more likely to respond favorably (Hamlin & Wilson, 2004). In other words, when a brand integrates its corporate social responsibility (CSR) with its core business, it is more likely to obtain a range of benefits relating to its CSR (Du, Bhattacharya, & Sen, 2007). Therefore, it is highly likely that congruence will allow the brand to generate positive returns, whereas a non-congruent relationship may even be detrimental to the brand (Gray, 2000; Hamlin & Wilson, 2004; Murphy, 1996; Simmons & Becker-Olsen, 2006; Welsh, 1999).

Despite the recognized importance of congruence, there are no clear guidelines to help managers assess whether a certain cause may be a good fit with their brand. Experimental research showing that fit matters has relied on extreme cases comparing “very good fit” with “very bad fit” (Hamlin & Wilson, 2004; Simmons & Becker-Olsen, 2006). Although in some instances it may be easy for marketing managers to determine “good fit,” this may not always be the case, forcing managers to rely on their instincts. In order to help alleviate this uncertainty and assist managers with precise determinants of fit, our objective is to examine different sub-dimensions of fit in the context of cause-marketing communication in order to establish better criteria for developing appropriate or fitting relationships between a brand and a social cause. This objective is grounded in two literature-based assumptions. First, prior research has shown the existence of an “overall fit” construct that is related to consumers’ attitude toward the sponsoring brand (Hamlin & Wilson, 2004; Simmons & Becker-Olsen, 2006). Second, good “overall fit” can be created in different ways, i.e., through different sub-dimensions of fit

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(Fleck & Quester, 2007; Heckler & Childers, 1992; Simmons & Becker-Olsen, 2006). Although some attempts at “dimensionalizing” fit have been made, these dimensions are still rather broad (Fleck & Quester, 2007) and are arguably difficult to apply in the managerial decision-making process.

In designing this study, our goal was to identify sub-dimensions of fit and determine which of these have the most significant impact on attitude toward the sponsorship. We also examine whether particular fit dimensions could be grouped in a logical fashion. These research interests were addressed through a two-step approach. First, we conducted an exploratory qualitative study of cause-marketing communication to generate possible sub-dimensions of fit. Second, we conducted a large-scale quantitative study to examine which of the identified sub-dimensions most significantly impact attitudes toward the cause-marketing relationship and whether individual sub-dimensions can be grouped together.

We have structured the paper in the following way. First, we briefly describe the current state of affairs in the cause-related marketing and fit literature. This serves as the foundation for study one, which qualitatively identifies the sub-dimensions of fit. Next, we present literature regarding the consequences of fit and conduct study two, examining which of the newly identified sub-dimensions of fit have the most significant impact on attitudes toward the sponsorship and whether individual sub-dimensions can be grouped together. We conclude by discussing the theoretical and managerial implications of our research as well as identifying some of the limitations and directions for future research.

1. Literature review

1.1. Cause-related marketing (CRM)

One visible way firms can act in a socially responsible manner (and also enhance their bottom line) is through sponsorship activities. In the last ten years sponsorship has grown faster than any other promotional activity. Sponsorship expenditures increased from \$13 billion worldwide in 1996 to more than \$50 billion in 2006 (IEG, 2006). Sponsorships are activities in which firms provide financial support to an event or group and in return receive publicized recognition of this contribution. More formally, sponsorship is defined as an investment, in cash or kind, in an activity in return for access to the exploitable commercial potential associated with that activity (Meenaghan, 1991). Although sponsorship is seen as one of the fastest growing areas of promotion, this is not reflected in the marketing literature (McDaniel, 1999). Prior research has primarily been case-oriented and filled with anecdotes, while theoretically driven research on sponsorship-linked marketing has been somewhat neglected (Cornwell & Maignan, 1998; Walliser, 2003).

Sponsoring social causes (cause-related marketing—CRM) is one way for a firm to act in a socially responsible manner and potentially benefit from its efforts. Cause-marketing (see Cone, 2009 for a historical review) has been defined as a “strategy designed to promote the achievement of marketing objectives via company support of social causes” (Barone, Miyazaki, & Taylor, 2000, p. 248). Simply stated, CRM is an association of a for-profit company with a non-profit organization, intended to promote the company's product or service and, at the same time, raise money or awareness for the non-profit. CRM is usually considered to be different from corporate philanthropy because firms do not simply donate funds to organizations but instead get involved in partnerships with non-profits for the benefit of both entities. CRM spending has consistently grown around 10% per year (IEG, 2006)—a trend that does not appear to be slowing. CRM can be beneficial to all parties involved. Non-profits benefit tremendously from additional funds and increased consumer awareness (Varadarajan & Menon, 1988), consumers benefit through the self-satisfaction of contributing to a worthy cause (Webb & Mohr, 1998), and firms benefit from their

association with a cause and the accompanying media attention (Barnes & Fitzgibbons, 1991; Bittar, 2002; Comiteau, 2003).

1.2. Do partners belong together (What is “fit”)?

Despite the increased popularity of CRM, recent research shows that not all CRM relationships have positive outcomes (Hoeffler & Keller, 2002). A lack of fit or congruence between the brand and the cause has been blamed for some of brand's inability to benefit from CRM. As such, some researchers suggest that relationships between organizations that fit well together are viewed as stronger and more favorable than relationships between organizations that do not fit well together (Basil & Herr, 2006). These researchers advise managers to evaluate the fit between their brand and the cause they support when developing a socially responsible strategy with a social cause. If the fit between the brand and the cause is perceived as poor, CRM initiatives can sometimes decrease consumers' purchase intent (Becker-Olsen, Cudmore, & Hill, 2006; Simmons & Becker-Olsen, 2006).

In contrast, some researchers suggest highly fitting relationships may raise consumers' skepticism about company motives and lead consumers to respond more positively to non-fitting relationships between cause and company (Ellen et al., 2000). Also, there is some evidence indicating no effect of fit, where fit between the cause and the brand does not influence attitudes or purchase intentions (Lafferty, 2007). Finally, it is also evident that the effect of fit is moderated by variables such as consumers' perception of the firm's motives, affinity customers hold for the social causes (Barone, Norman, & Miyazaki, 2007), and consumers' level of brand consciousness (Nan & Heo, 2007).

The idea of fit, match, or congruence between the sponsor and the organization, event, activity, individual, or sport is not only confined to sponsorship. In the strategic management literature, Venkatraman (1989) proposes that a match (fit) between the structure and strategy of a firm leads to administrative efficiencies and better performance. Research in advertising has shown that advertising effectiveness improves when there is a good fit between the product and the endorser/celebrity (Kamins, 1990; Till & Busler, 2000). Perhaps most commonly, fit has been used as a key criterion (Bottomley & Doyle, 1996; Keller & Aaker, 1992; Sunde & Brodie, 1993), or as a criterion that interacts with the parent brand's quality (Echambadi, Arroniz, Reinartz, & Lee, 2006), when explaining the success of brand extensions.

Despite assertions that fit is important, definitions and operationalizations of fit have been generally vague. The term “fit” itself has not been consistently used in the literature. Interchangeable terms like “congruence” (Heckler & Childers, 1992; Speed & Thompson, 2000), “similarity” (Broniarczyk & Alba, 1994; Gwinner & Eaton, 1999), “typicality” (Ladwein, 1994), and “relevancy” (Rodgers, 2003) have been used to describe the link between sponsoring and sponsored entities.

The strength of the link depends on the perceived similarity between partners (McDaniel, 1999) and can be explained in terms of image or functional similarity (Gwinner, 1997; Gwinner & Eaton, 1999). Hamlin and Wilson (2004, p. 665) summarize their review of the literature by saying “the term ‘good fit’ is very loosely defined.... Definitions of ‘fit’ are based around common values or common target groups—if they are defined at all.” Simmons and Becker-Olsen (2006) draw on Bridges, Keller, and Sood (2000) and Park, Milberg, and Lawson (1991) and define the degree of fit between a cause and a brand as “high when the two are perceived as congruent (i.e., as going together), whether that congruity is derived from mission, products, markets, technologies, attributes, brand concepts, or any other key association (p. 155).” Finally, Fleck and Quester (2007) argue in favor of explaining fit as a two-dimensional construct. The first dimension is the *relevancy* of associations and explains “the degree to which the information contained in the stimulus favors (or hinders) the identification of the theme or message being communicated” (p. 978). The second is *expectancy* and “refers to the degree to which an item or

information falls into a predetermined schema or a structure evoked by the theme” (p. 978).

Although *relevancy* and *expectancy* appear to be straightforward criteria to determine whether a relationship fits, we are still left questioning what exactly makes a relationship relevant and what makes it expected. Simmons and Becker-Olsen (2006) argue that fit is derived from mission, attributes, and any other key association. Adding “any other key association” at the end of their definition presents a clear indication that our understanding of what determines consumers’ perception of overall fit is still vague. The question of whether a relationship is relevant due to the partners’ common mission or expected due to similar imagery used by the partners is still unanswered in current literature. In other words, fit may be created in multiple ways, i.e., through different sub-dimensions that contribute to a perception of overall fit, but we haven’t yet identified those sub-dimensions.

As seen from the list of potential fit dimensions given above, there is relatively little guidance as to what constitutes fit, and marketing managers have been forced to determine fit through the exercise of reason and common sense. In experimental studies, researchers have alleviated this potential confusion (as to what constitutes high fit) by creating extreme situations of high- vs. low-fit relationships. However, marketing managers may not always be faced with such clear contrasts. Due to the lack of theoretical and empirical development in this area, we still have no clear understanding of what fit is and, in situations such as this, “common sense may be a most treacherous ally” (Hamlin & Wilson, 2004, p. 666).

Generally, authors have defined fit in terms of its determinants. Partners fit together if there is an association or *relevancy* between them (d’Astous & Bitz, 1995). They fit together if there is a degree of consistency between partnership expectations and brand schemas (Jagre, Watson, & Watson, 2001). The association between partners can result from perceived function or image similarity (McDonald, 1991). More recently, Becker-Olsen and Simmons (2002) explained the association between partners by “native fit” (where partners’ names go well together) and “created fit” (where communication activities are used to create a fitting relationship). As a result, whereas the research community seems to be in agreement that the determinants of fit are numerous and fit may be comprised of multiple sub-dimensions, there is no guidance as to which sub-dimensions are the most meaningful. Because of this gap in the literature, we present the following research question and answer it through a qualitative research technique.

RQ1: What sub-dimensions of fit contribute to consumers’ perception of overall fit?

2. Study 1 (qualitative): identifying sub-dimensions of fit

To improve our understanding of the determinants that contribute to the overall perception of fit, we began with a qualitative approach. Twenty-two graduate business students from a large American university were presented with 16 cause-marketing advertisements from popular magazines where various brands endorsed the Susan G. Komen Breast Cancer Foundation. This foundation was selected because it is well known and associated with more than 300 brands, making it a suitable context for our study (Hoeffler & Keller, 2002). We looked for as many determinants of fit as our study participants were able to provide. In an open-ended questionnaire, the respondents were asked to identify how the Komen Foundation (cause) fits with the various partner brands. Study participants were instructed that “marketers who partner with social causes often believe that their brand “fits” with the cause they are promoting.” They were then asked to take a minute to look at each of the advertisements and write down how they felt the advertised brand “fits” with the Susan G. Komen Breast Cancer Foundation. Fit was defined for the participants as something suitable, appropriate, or proper, something in harmony or accord, and something that conforms to a particular shape or size. This definition of fit came from the Merriam-Webster Dictionary.

Three researchers analyzed the content of the qualitative responses and identified ten sub-dimensions contributing to the perceived overall fit between a cause and a brand: 1) visibility of the relationship (VISIBILITY); 2) explicitness of the relationship (EXPLICITNESS); 3) slogan compatibility (SLOGAN); 4) mission agreement (MISSION); 5) color or visual compatibility (COLORCOMP); 6) common target market (TARGETMKT); 7) promotional activities compatibility (PROMOTION); 8) geographic compatibility (GEO); 9) local attributes (LOCAL); and 10) active involvement (INVOLVEMENT). Definitions, examples, and the subsequent operationalization of each sub-dimension are presented in Table 1.

While the respondents were encouraged to think of and identify dimensions of fit for each brand with the Komen Foundation, several of the respondents volunteered suggestions such as “this brand–cause has no fit whatsoever...I don’t see a natural fit between this brand and Komen....” Although anecdotal and derived from a small sample, these comments reinforce the impression that sometimes brands team up with social causes in combinations that do not make sense in the minds of consumers.

3. Factor analysis of fit sub-dimensions and their effect on attitude toward the sponsorship and the brand

Following the identification of ten sub-dimensions of fit, we proceeded to investigate whether we could logically group any of the sub-dimensions into more general categories. This work addressed our second research question.

RQ2: Can sub-dimensions of fit be grouped together in a logical fashion?

In addition to answering the second research question, the final objective of our study is to examine the relationship between fit sub-dimensions and consumers’ attitudes toward the sponsorship and the brand. Theoretically, the value of fit can be explained by congruence theory.

In regards to sponsorship, congruence theory has been used to evaluate the functional or image-related similarity between the sponsee and the sponsoring brand (Gwinner, 1997; Grohs, Wagner, & Vsetecka, 2004). An example is viewing a race and seeing a sponsorship by a *running shoe* brand as appropriate and memorable, while seeing sponsorship by a *lawn fertilizer* brand as non-appropriate and non-memorable. Good fit between the sponsor and the sponsee could facilitate a long-term relationship between the two parties. When applied to cause-marketing, the degree of similarity represents the similarity between the cause and the sponsoring brand, where good fit between the sponsor and the cause could possibly facilitate a long-term relationship between the two parties.

Empirical studies have shown that sponsor–sponsee fit affects outcomes such as sponsorship awareness (Johar & Pham, 1999), attitude toward sponsorship (Hamlin & Wilson, 2004; McDaniel, 1999; Simmons & Becker-Olsen, 2006), brand image (Gwinner & Eaton, 1999; Becker-Olsen & Simmons, 2002), brand attitude (Rodgers, 2003; Roy, 2000; Speed & Thompson, 2000), and brand favorability (Speed & Thompson, 2000). Essentially, fit is important because high-fit sponsorships are consistent with consumer expectations of the brand and low-fit sponsorships are not. The level of fit influences clarity and attitude toward the sponsorship (Becker-Olsen et al., 2006) which, in turn, could affect brand equity (Keller, 1993).

Drawing on congruence theory, the match-up hypothesis offers a perspective on how a consumer’s prior perception of the brand influences the perceived fit between brand and cause. An endorsement will be more reliable and will enhance the image of the brand when relevant characteristics in the image or function of the cause match the perceived image or functions of the brand (Gwinner & Eaton, 1999; Becker-Olsen & Simmons, 2002). If the degree of match-up between the image of the cause and the image of the brand is low, then consumers reduce their acceptance of the endorsement and can

Table 1

Definition, examples, and operationalization of each sub-dimension.

Dimension with composite reliability (CR)* and average variance extracted (AVE)**	Definition	Example	Operationalization of sub-dimension (with loading)***
Visibility of relationship (VISIBILITY) CR = 0.93 Ave = 0.83	The extent to which promotion prominently features support for the cause.	A small ribbon (Komen) in the corner of the ad vs. a large ribbon in the middle of the ad.	Please indicate how visible is the relationship between brand X and cause Y. ○ Not visible–Visible (0.90) ○ Obscure–Obvious (0.90) ○ Unclear–Clear (0.91)
Relationship explicitness (EXPLICITNESS) CR = 0.94 Ave = 0.86	The extent to which the nature of the partnership (degree of support) is spelled out to consumers in the ad.	Serta will donate \$290,000 to Komen Foundation.	Please indicate how well the relationship between the brand X and the cause Y is explained on the ad. ○ Ambiguous–Complete (0.94) ○ Vague–In detail (0.94) ○ Bad–Good (0.94)
Slogan (SLOGAN) CR = 0.93 Ave = 0.78	The extent to which the promotional slogan simultaneously supports the brand and the cause.	“Support the Girls”—slogan by Wacoal bras supporting Komen.	Brand X's* slogan... ○ Is a good fit with cause Y (0.96) ○ Works well with cause Y (0.95) ○ Is a clever play on words incorporating cause Y (0.73) ○ Is relevant to cause Y (0.88)
Mission (MISSION) CR = 0.93 Ave = 0.82	The extent to which the overall mission of the brand is aligned with the mission of the cause.	Lean Cuisine and Komen both have healthy living as their mission.	Brand X's mission or product... ○ Is a good fit with cause Y (0.88) ○ Evokes similar feelings to that of cause Y (0.92) ○ Seem relevant, in terms of function, to cause Y (0.93)
Visuals/color (COLORCOMP) CR = 0.94 Ave = 0.83	The extent to which the visual presentation and colors of the brand and the cause overlap with each other.	M&M using pink candies and packaging marked with pink ribbons when supporting Komen.	Brand X's use of color or visual attributes... ○ Is a good fit with cause Y (0.90) ○ Are similar to colors/images associated with cause Y (0.91) ○ Are complementary with cause Y (0.92)
Target market (TARGETMKT) CR = 0.92 Ave = 0.81	The extent to which the brand's and the cause's target markets overlap.	Kitchen Aid and Komen (both targeting adult women).	Brand X's target market or users... ○ Are a good fit with cause Y (0.88) ○ Are similar to the people served by cause Y (0.92) ○ Remind you of the people associated with cause Y (0.90)
Promotional activities (PROMOTION) CR = 0.81 Ave = 0.61	The extent to which the brand's promotional activities also encourage support for the cause.	New Balance promoting running (Komen's biggest event is Race for the Cure)	Brand X's promotional activities... ○ Are a good fit with cause Y (0.72) ○ Use spokespeople/celebrities who are associated with cause Y (0.65) ○ Endorse events which seem complementary to cause Y (0.94)
Geographic compatibility (GEO) CR = 0.94 Ave = 0.84	The extent to which the brand and the cause have ties to the same geographic area.	A national brand (Remax) supporting national cause (Komen). A local brand (American Equity Mortgage—St. Louis) supporting Kid Smart (St. Louis organization)	The location(s) associated with brand X... ○ Is a good fit with cause Y (0.91) ○ Is similar to the location(s) associated with cause Y (0.94) ○ Matches with the location in which cause Y operates (0.91)
Local attributes (LOCAL) CR = 0.96 Ave = 0.89	The extent to which the cause is affiliated with the local market.	Brand supporting the St. Louis Zoo foundation (St. Louis is the local market).	Indicate how closely cause Y is associated with St. Louis, Missouri. ○ Cause Y fits well with St. Louis (0.92) ○ Cause Y is closely associated with St. Louis (0.97) ○ Cause Y is highly related to St. Louis (0.95)
Active involvement (INVOLVEMENT) CR = 0.91 Ave = 0.79	The extent to which support of the cause is determined by the actions of the consumer.	Yoplait yogurt “Save lids to save lives” campaign.	Indicate how brand X encourages consumers to take an active role in supporting cause Y. ○ The brand encourages consumers to get involved with cause Y (0.88) ○ The brand's mission is conducive to involvement with cause Y (0.88) ○ The brand contributes to greater involvement of consumers with cause Y (0.91)
Attitude to the sponsorship (AS) CR = 0.95 Ave = 0.87	Adopted from Simmons and Becker-Olsen, 2006		Please indicate your attitude to the sponsorship between Firm X and Cause Y: ○ Negative–Positive (0.94) ○ Unfavorable–Favorable (0.93) ○ Bad–Good (0.94)
Attitude to the brand (AB) CR = 0.95 Ave = 0.88	Adopted from Simmons and Becker-Olsen, 2006		Please indicate your attitude to the brand: ○ Negative–Positive (0.95) ○ Unfavorable–Favorable (0.95) ○ Bad–Good (0.94)
Overall fit (FIT) CR = 0.94 Ave = 0.86	Adopted from Simmons and Becker-Olsen, 2006		Please indicate the degree of overall fit or match between brand X and cause Y. ○ Dissimilar–Similar (0.92) ○ Low fit–High fit (0.95) ○ Does not make sense–Makes sense (0.91)

CR*, Ave**, loading***—from quantitative Study 2.

even develop a negative evaluation of the endorsement (Jagre et al., 2001; McDonald, 1991). Incongruence muddles consumers' perception of the brand's positioning and alters processing of sponsorship information, which leads to reduced likeability of the brand–cause relationship (Simmons & Becker-Olsen, 2006). Both Hamlin and Wilson (2004) and Simmons and Becker-Olsen (2006) show that a high degree of fit between the brand and the cause improves consumers' attitude toward the sponsorship and the brand. Thus, we validate our sub-dimensions of fit by examining whether high fit indeed translates into improved attitude toward the sponsorship.

H1. Fit is positively related to attitude toward the sponsorship.

We propose, however, that the rewards of strategically matching a brand and a cause in a cause-marketing campaign are not limited to the attitude toward the sponsorship. In fact, Kamins and Gupta (1994) have shown that, in the field of celebrity endorsers, strategically matching the celebrity and the product improves the attitude toward the product being endorsed. In terms of sponsorship, this is corroborated by Speed and Thompson (2000) and Rodgers (2003) who found congruence between sponsor and property improves attitudes toward the sponsor. We predict this relationship to hold true in the arena of cause-marketing as well.

Finally, consumers' attitude toward the sponsorship and consumers' attitude toward the brand are not independent of one another. Consumers' attitude toward the brand is influenced by the behaviors (sponsorship activities) in which the brand is involved. A favorable attitude toward the sponsorship should result in a more favorable attitude toward the brand caused by the creation of a new affective association for the brand (Simmons & Becker-Olsen, 2006). In other words, consumers develop a more favorable opinion of the brand if the brand is involved in sponsorship relationships that are also perceived favorably. This is consistent with previous findings showing that consumers' attitude toward the brand is highly related to their attitude toward brand alliances (Simonin & Ruth, 1998) and brand extensions (Sullivan, 1990). As such, we expect that a positive feeling toward the sponsorship mediates the relationship between fit and attitude toward the brand (Kamins & Gupta, 1994).

H2. Fit is positively related to attitude toward the brand (sponsor) and this relationship is mediated by attitude toward the sponsorship.

To answer our second research question and to test the hypotheses, we followed up the initial qualitative study with a large-scale quantitative study.

4. Study 2 (quantitative)

4.1. Sample

The participants in this study were undergraduate business students from a large American university. We created a question-

naire that asked each respondent to view a set of nine cause-marketing advertisements and to identify how well the brand and the cause fit on each sub-dimension identified in the qualitative study. To increase the robustness of our quantitative study, we created two sets of cause-marketing advertisements, each of which consisted of nine ads that paired brands with non-profit social causes. We measured respondents' prior knowledge of the selected brands and causes (split-sample analysis is provided in the results section that examines consistency of the results across different groups). We used six of the original Komen ads and complemented them with 12 advertisements for a variety of other endorsed causes. The first group consisted of 42 individuals and the second group consisted of 50 individuals. As each respondent evaluated nine separate ads, this resulted in 828 observations. Two incomplete observations were discarded, resulting in a usable sample of 826 observations. Table 2 outlines the brand–cause pair for each ad.

4.2. Measures

Because no previous study explores the ten sub-dimensions of fit, original items had to be developed to measure each sub-dimension. We relied on the written comments provided by the study participants in the qualitative study in addition to several other experts who collaborated on the development of items for each sub-dimension. All measurements were discussed until a consensus was reached and three to four items were developed to capture each sub-dimension. The items for overall fit were adopted from Simmons and Becker-Olsen (2006) (Table 1).

4.3. Validity and reliability of sub-dimensions

All perceptual measures were subjected to assessments of dimensionality, reliability, and validity. First, we assessed reliability and convergent validity through a series of measurement models using LISREL 8.80 (Joreskog, Sorbom, du Toit, & du Toit, 2000). Based on the measurement models, all items had loadings above the recommended 0.6 threshold (Anderson & Gerbing, 1988). We also calculated composite reliability and average variance extracted for each latent construct. Composite reliabilities (>0.7) and average variance extracted (>0.5) all exceeded the recommended thresholds (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). These findings are presented in Table 1, and lead us to conclude that all items were acceptable and reliable.

Considering the conceptual similarities between the different sub-dimensions of fit, it was highly important to establish whether the constructs demonstrated discriminant validity. This was accomplished through the assessment of a full confirmatory factor analysis (CFA). The model fit was evaluated using a series of indices recommended by Gerbing and Anderson (1992) and Hu and Bentler (1999). The CFA produced acceptable fit as evidenced by the CFA Fit Statistics: $\chi^2 = 2910.05$ ($p < 0.001$); RMSEA = 0.06; SRMR = 0.03; NFI = 0.98; NNFI = 0.98. Although the model chi-square is significant, which is not unusual with large samples, other fit indices indicate acceptable fit.

Table 2
List of brands and causes.

Group 1		Group 2	
Brand	Cause	Brand	Cause
American Equity Mortgage	KidSmart	American Century Investments	Lance Armstrong Foundation
Bristol-Myers Squibb	American Diabetes Ass.	Healing Garden	Nature Conservancy
California Almonds	American Heart Association	Kellogg's	American Heart Association
Echo	Ducks Unlimited	Re/Max	Children's Miracle Network
Pantene	Women's Cancer Research	Schiff	Arthritis Foundation
Pedigree	Petsmart Charities	Yuban	Rainforest Alliance
Tomboy Tools	Susan G. Komen Foundation	Dell	Susan G. Komen Foundation
Yoplait	Susan G. Komen Foundation	Kitchen Aid	Susan G. Komen Foundation
Serta	Susan G. Komen Foundation	New Balance	Susan G. Komen Foundation

Table 3
Correlations between 10 sub-dimensions of fit and attitudinal measures.

	VIS [^]	EXP	SLO	MIS	COL	TAR	PRO	GEO	LOC	INV	ATS	ATB
VISIBILITY	1											
EXPLICITNESS	.642*	1										
SLOGAN	.417*	.544*	1									
MISSION	.421*	.451*	.689*	1								
COLORCOMP	.368*	.443*	.470*	.371*	1							
TARGETMKT	.316*	.305*	.509*	.689*	.325*	1						
PROMOTION	.396*	.434*	.545*	.612*	.393*	.629*	1					
GEO	.340*	.384*	.490*	.551*	.319*	.559*	.572*	1				
LOCAL	.298*	.313*	.285*	.247*	.224*	.297*	.306*	.448*	1			
INVOLVEMENT	.415*	.557*	.545*	.447*	.445*	.408*	.537*	.433*	.362*	1		
Attitude to sponsorship (ATS)	.444*	.413*	.430*	.437*	.433*	.376*	.371*	.322*	.254*	.419*	1	
Attitude to brand (ATB)	.298*	.360*	.347*	.377*	.342*	.368*	.370*	.338*	.276*	.367*	.453*	1

*Pearson Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed). $N = 826$.

[^]Sub-dimension names shortened to first 3 letters.

Discriminant validity was evident in that no confidence interval for the phi correlations between pairs of dimensions contained 1.0 (Anderson & Gerbing, 1988), and all squared phi correlations were less than the respective variance extracted estimates for all pairs of constructs (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). Overall, our constructs have shown acceptable reliability and validity and were deemed acceptable for further analysis. The correlation matrix between the 10 sub-dimensions (each measured as the simple average of the items pertaining to that sub-dimension), attitude toward the sponsorship, and attitude toward the brand is presented in Table 3.

5. Results

5.1. Can sub-dimensions of fit be grouped in a logical fashion?

Each sub-dimension was measured with three to four items, each of which loaded above .6 on its corresponding factor. Each sub-dimension was then transformed to the simple average of the items that pertained to it. Due to significant correlations between sub-dimensions and in attempt to answer research question two, we proceeded to conduct factor analysis for structure detection in SPSS (Cronk, 1999; Stevens, 2002). A principal component analysis was conducted on the 10 items with oblique rotation (oblimin). The Kaiser–Meyer–Olkin (KMO) measure verified this sampling adequacy for the analysis ($KMO = .887$). Bartlett's test of sphericity [$\lambda^2(45) = 3898.84$, $p < .001$] indicates that correlations between items were sufficiently large for principal component analysis. Two components had eigenvalues over 1 and in combination explained 61% of the variance. This suggests that two latent influences are associated with the measure of fit in the cause-marketing communication. Table 4 shows the factor loadings after rotation.

Table 4
Rotated factor matrix^a (Pattern Matrix).

	Fit component	
	1	2
TARGETMKT	.958	
MISSION	.807	
GEO	.772	
PROMOTION	.751	
SLOGAN	.516	
EXPLICITNESS		.915
VISIBILITY		.844
COLORCOMP		.632
INVOLVEMENT		.593
LOCAL		.300

Extraction method: principal component analysis.

Rotation method: oblique (Oblimin) with Kaiser normalization.

^a Rotation converged in 8 iterations.

The first rotated factor is most highly correlated with TARGETMKT, MISSION, GEO, PROMOTION, and SLOGAN. The second factor is most highly correlated with EXPLICITNESS, VISIBILITY, COLORCOMP, INVOLVEMENT, and LOCAL. Thus, factor analysis for structure detection indicates two major groupings of sub-dimensions of fit.

The goal of the initial qualitative study was to identify as many sub-dimensions of fit as possible. The quantitative study's factor analysis results indicate that a distinction between fit driven by the *prominence* of the relationship between the brand and the cause, and fit driven by *marketing strategy* should be made. Fit driven by the *prominence* of the relationship includes EXPLICITNESS, VISIBILITY, COLORCOMP, INVOLVEMENT, and LOCAL, or the manner in which the cause relationship is presented and explained to potential customers. Fit driven by marketing strategy includes TARGETMKT, MISSION, GEO, PROMOTION, and SLOGAN and deals with the partners' similarity in segmentation, targeting, and positioning. These results positively answer our second research question and indicate that sub-dimensions of fit can be grouped in a logical and credible fashion.

5.2. Linking fit sub-dimensions with attitude toward the sponsorship and the brand

As part of our second (quantitative) study where respondents were asked to evaluate the degree of fit between the brand and the cause on the newly identified sub-dimensions, we also included measures for attitude toward the sponsorship (AS) and attitude toward the brand (AB). These measures were adopted from Simmons and Becker-Olsen (2006). As indicated in Table 1, all factor loadings were highly significant and composite reliability and average variance extracted exceeded recommended thresholds, which led us to conclude that the constructs' psychometric properties were acceptable for further analysis. Our sample for this part of the analysis was 826 usable cases from 92 respondents.

5.3. Sub-dimensions' effect on attitudes

Testing our two hypotheses required several different steps. The first step was to examine whether each of the ten sub-dimensions has a significant effect on attitude toward the sponsorship and attitude toward the brand. To do this, we first calculated the simple average of items for each sub-dimension. Because sub-dimensions and attitudes are interval-scaled, we decided to use simple linear regression in SPSS (Cronk, 1999; Stevens, 2002) to examine the impact of each sub-dimension on attitude toward the sponsorship and toward the brand. The results of the simple regressions are equivalent to the correlations presented in Table 3 ($\beta = \text{correlation}$); therefore, we can see that each of the ten sub-dimensions significantly predicts attitude toward the sponsorship and toward the brand. These results offer support for the first hypothesis and for the first part of the second hypothesis. We also

wanted to examine the significance of each of the newly discovered sub-dimensions to attitude toward the sponsorship and toward the brand in a more dynamic and non-isolated situation. We therefore decided to explore which sub-dimensions are significant when examined as a group of factors that determines attitude.

A multiple linear regression was run to predict study participants' attitudes toward the sponsorship and toward the brand based on 10 sub-dimensions discovered in our qualitative study. A significant relationship was found for both dependent variables. In the case of attitude toward the sponsorship, VISIBILITY, MISSION, COLORCOMP, TARGETMKT, and INVOLVEMENT were found to be significant predictors. In the case of attitude toward the brand, EXPLICITNESS, COLORCOMP, TARGETMKT, LOCAL, and INVOLVEMENT were found to be significant predictors. Complete results of both multiple linear regressions are presented in Table 5.

5.4. The effects of macro-dimensions (marketing strategy fit and prominence fit) on attitude

Although we were able to demonstrate that, individually, each sub-dimension of fit positively influences attitude, we also wanted to examine the predictive power of the two macro-dimensions developed earlier in the paper. We therefore examined whether each of the two macro-dimensions has a significant effect on attitude toward the sponsorship and attitude toward the brand. All four relationships examined were significant. *Marketing strategy fit* and *prominence fit* significantly influenced attitude toward the sponsorship and toward brand. A multiple linear regression was also run to predict study participants' attitude based on the two macro-dimensions of fit taken together. Here again, the macro-dimensions of fit significantly predicted attitude. Complete results of the four simple linear regressions and the two multiple regressions are presented in Table 6.

Table 5
Multiple regressions: micro-dimensions' impact on attitudes.

Relationship	β -standardized regression coefficient
VISIBILITY $\rightarrow$ AS	.211*
EXPLICITNESS $\rightarrow$ AS	.013
SLOGAN $\rightarrow$ AS	.049
MISSION $\rightarrow$ AS	.139*
COLORCOMP $\rightarrow$ AS	.202*
TARGETMKT $\rightarrow$ AS	.089*
PROMOTION $\rightarrow$ AS	-.030
GEO $\rightarrow$ AS	-.025
LOCAL $\rightarrow$ AS	.043
INVOLVEMENT $\rightarrow$ AS	.119*
N	826
F (ANOVA)	42.77*
R ²	.344
df	10, 815
VISIBILITY $\rightarrow$ AB	.013
EXPLICITNESS $\rightarrow$ AB	.118*
SLOGAN $\rightarrow$ AB	-.031
MISSION $\rightarrow$ AB	.097
COLORCOMP $\rightarrow$ AB	.135*
TARGETMKT $\rightarrow$ AB	.121*
PROMOTION $\rightarrow$ AB	.048
GEO $\rightarrow$ AB	.033
LOCAL $\rightarrow$ AB	.093*
INVOLVEMENT $\rightarrow$ AB	.086*
N	826
F (ANOVA)	27.02*
R ²	.249
df	10, 815

AS—attitude toward sponsorship.

AB—attitude toward brand.

* $p < .05$.

5.5. The interaction between fit and familiarity and its effect on attitude

We studied a wide range of brands and causes. As such, one might argue that some of the brands and causes are more relevant and/or familiar to participants than others, which might have some effect on attitude. In other words, one might argue that the relationship between fit and attitude toward sponsorship and toward brand depends on an individual's level of familiarity with the brand and the cause. We used linear regression to determine if there is an interaction between fit and familiarity. In this instance, we used the overall measure of fit (see Table 1). This was a three-item measure indicating how *similar* the brand and cause are, the *overall fit* between the two, and whether this partnership *makes sense*. This measure showed a high level of reliability, with Cronbach's Alpha = .94. The familiarity measure was a three-item construct (unfamiliar/familiar, do not recognize/recognize, have not heard of/have heard of). Scales measuring familiarity with the brand ($\alpha = .98$) and familiarity with the cause ($\alpha = .97$) indicated a high level of reliability. All of independent variables were mean-centered before inclusion in the model.

a) Impact of interaction between fit and familiarity on attitude toward the brand.

A significant regression equation was found ($F(6,819) = 76.72$, $p < .001$, $R^2 = .360$). We found a significant main effect of brand familiarity ($F(1,819) = 147.83$, $p < .001$), cause familiarity ($F(1,819) = 40.48$, $p < .001$), and overall fit ($F(1,819) = 113.87$, $p < .001$). The interaction between brand familiarity and overall fit was not significant ($F(1,819) = .078$, $p > .05$), while the interaction between cause familiarity and overall fit was significant ($F(1,819) = 6.90$, $p < .01$, $\beta = .048$). Our results indicate that, as familiarity with the cause increases, the effect of fit on attitude toward the brand increases as well. In other words, fit significantly influences attitude toward the brand, especially as individuals become more familiar with the social causes supported by a brand. For example, an individual who is familiar with the Susan G. Komen Breast Cancer Foundation will have a better attitude toward Lean Cuisine (brand supporting healthy living) than toward Dell (computer manufacturer) because Lean Cuisine is a better fit with the Susan G. Komen Foundation. Individuals not familiar with the Susan G. Komen Foundation will have similar attitude toward the brand regardless of the fit between the brand and the social cause (same attitude toward Lean Cuisine and Dell).

b) Impact of interaction between fit and familiarity on attitude toward the sponsorship.

A significant regression equation was found ($F(6,819) = 73.08$, $p < .001$, $R^2 = .349$). We found significant main effects for brand familiarity ($F(1,819) = 26.05$, $p < .001$), cause familiarity ($F(1,819) = 39.12$, $p < .001$), and overall fit ($F(1,819) = 266.93$, $p < .001$). The interaction between brand familiarity and overall fit again was not significant ($F(1,819) = .041$, $p > .05$), while the interaction between cause familiarity and overall fit was again significant ($F(1,819) = 10.415$, $p < .01$, $\beta = -.051$). Our results indicate that as familiarity with the cause increases, the effect of fit on attitude toward the sponsorship diminishes. In other words, the importance of fit diminishes as individuals become more familiar with the social causes supported by the brands. For example, an individual who is familiar with Greenpeace will equally evaluate sponsorship between Greenpeace and Tesla (a manufacturer of electric cars, and Greenpeace and McDonalds (fast food). An explanation for this finding can be found in the recent economic situation. The current economy has depleted the funds of many non-profits and consumers familiar with social causes are eager to support them, regardless of the origin of that support. Consequently, they evaluate sponsorship between fitting and non-fitting partners similarly.

Table 6
Regressions: macro-dimensions' impact on attitudes.

	Simple regression				Multiple regression			
	Mkt strategy fit → AS	Mkt strategy fit → AB	Prominence fit → AS	Prominence fit → AB	Mkt strategy + prominence → AS		Mkt strategy + prominence → AB	
					MKTS	PRO	MKTS	PRO
β -standardized regression coefficient	.476*	.440*	.540*	.450*	.212*	.401*	.253*	.283*
N	826	826	826	826	826		826	
F (ANOVA)	241.33*	197.96*	339.59*	209.56*	191.123*		129.227*	
R ²	.227	.194	.292	.203	.317		.239	
df (df1, df2)	1, 824	1, 824	1, 824	1, 824	2, 823		2, 823	

AS—attitude toward sponsorship, AB—attitude toward brand, MKTS—mkt strategy, PRO—prominence.

* $p < .05$.

5.6. Mediating role of attitude toward the sponsorship

Thus far, the results presented support H_1 and the first part of H_2 . The second part of H_2 predicts a mediating effect of the attitude toward the sponsorship on the *fit-attitude toward the brand* relationship. This prediction is examined by testing the indirect effect of overall fit on the attitude toward the brand via attitude toward the sponsorship. The measure for overall fit was adopted from Simmons and Becker-Olsen (2006) and, as indicated in Table 1, all factor loadings were highly significant. Composite reliability and average variance extracted exceeded recommended thresholds, which indicates the construct's psychometric properties are acceptable. For attitude towards sponsorship to mediate the relationship between fit and attitude toward brand, several conditions must be met: 1) Fit has to be significantly associated with attitude toward brand; 2) Fit has to be significantly associated with attitude toward sponsorship; 3) Attitude toward sponsorship has to be significantly associated with attitude toward brand (after controlling for Fit); and 4) The impact of fit on attitude toward brand must decrease significantly after controlling for attitude toward sponsorship.

Our results satisfy all four conditions. Fit is directly and significantly (at .001 level) associated with attitude toward brand ($\beta = .371$). Fit is also directly and significantly (at .001 level) associated with attitude toward sponsorship ($\beta = .516$). After controlling for fit, attitude toward sponsorship is directly and significantly (at the .001 level) associated with attitude toward brand ($\beta = .356$). Finally, after controlling for attitude toward sponsorship, the impact of fit on attitude toward brand is significantly less ($\beta = .187$) than before controlling for attitude toward sponsorship. Such results indicate that, in the context of cause-marketing communication, attitude toward sponsorship partially mediates the relationship between fit and attitude towards the brand. Stated differently, our results show that fit matters even after accounting for attitude toward sponsorship.

The indirect effect of overall fit was also calculated by LISREL 8.80 (Joreskog et al., 2000) and is significant ($\beta = 0.21, p < 0.001$). In addition, the Sobel test of mediation (Sobel, 1982) was conducted to test the mediating ability of attitude toward the sponsorship. In our case, the Sobel test statistic was equal to 11.25 and was significant at $p < .001$. These results therefore provide support for the second part of H_2 .

6. Discussion of results

Our research takes us one step closer to developing a foundation that can guide managers in developing fitting CRM relationships. A combination of qualitative and quantitative research identified ten sub-dimensions of fit (see Table 1) that individually significantly influence sponsorship and brand attitudes. Perhaps more importantly, factor analysis indicated that two latent variables are related to the dimension of overall fit. We identified these two latent variables as *marketing strategy fit* and *prominence fit*. Each of these two macro-dimensions of fit consists of five sub-dimensions identified in the

qualitative study. *Prominence fit* relates to the manner in which the cause relationship is presented and explained to potential customers while the *marketing strategy fit* dimension deals with the partners' similarity in segmentation, targeting, and positioning. Both macro-dimensions of fit have positive and significant effect on sponsorship and brand attitudes. This indicates that natural (*marketing strategy*) fit is very important but, at the same time, the signals received by consumers could lead to high levels of *prominence fit*, which may then lead to improved sponsorship and brand attitudes.

Our results indicate that the attitude generated by the cause-related marketing strategy not only depends on congruence between the cause and the brand but also on the interaction between fit and familiarity with the social cause. Greater familiarity with the social cause diminishes the effect of fit on attitude toward sponsorship. At the same time greater familiarity with the social cause increases the effect of fit on attitude toward brand. Such results corroborate our expectations that consumers have a high evaluation of brands when those brands are involved in partnerships that make sense. Interestingly, consumers who are familiar with social causes seem to care little about the origin of support when evaluating sponsorship relationships.

Our research takes us closer to developing a foundation that can guide managers in developing CRM relationships perceived as fitting. Our analysis has identified ten specific sub-dimensions of fit that can be grouped into two larger sub-dimensions of fit, which significantly affect sponsorship and brand attitudes. These findings go beyond some of the current proposed multidimensional measurements of fit (Fleck & Quester, 2007), which are still vague and not very management friendly. The reasons a particular relationship is deemed "relevant" or "expected" (Fleck & Quester, 2007) can be explained by underlying determinants of fit like those found in this study.

Finally, a positive attitude toward the brand might be the ultimate goal of brand managers, so we outlined a number of steps that can be taken to improve this attitude level. However, our results also suggest that attitude toward the sponsorship mediates relationship between fit and attitude toward the brand. Brand building is a long process, of which one step is to involve the brand in positively viewed sponsorships. Results of this study provide details that might assist one in building a sponsorship relationship that makes sense to consumers, is viewed as "natural," and contributes to the brand's long-term growth.

7. Limitations and future research

Our findings need to be considered in light of some limitations. Any study employing student respondents can be accused of external validity shortcomings. Although we recognize the critical role of external validity in the research process (McGrath & Brinberg, 1983), because this is a theory-building and pioneering research study, we placed a heavier emphasis on internal validity, which can be achieved by employing a relatively homogeneous student sample (Cook & Campbell, 1979). While we aimed for high levels of internal validity,

we recognize that a broader and more robust subject pool, as well as broader stimuli, might have identified additional dimensions of fit not examined in this paper.

One should also understand that CRM is only one type of sponsorship. CRM places more emphasis on altruism than other types of sponsorship (e.g., supporting a sports team or sporting event). As such, these results should be verified in other sponsorship settings and additional variables (such as consumers' level of altruism) should be examined in the future. In addition, future research should attempt to include additional factors in examining relationships investigated in this paper. For example, consumer cynicism could play a role in evaluating cause-marketing communication. As Yoon, Gurhan-Canli, and Schwarz (2006) suggest, cause-marketing could improve attitudes toward the brand when consumers see the partnership as sincere. Finally, an interesting avenue for future research would be to examine how expressed financial support for the cause influences the relationships examined in this study. In other words, something that should be examined is the brand's expenditure on the cause and the proportion of the consumer price that goes toward the cause. We expect cause-marketing will be evaluated more favorably when a brand spends more and contributes more of the proceeds to the cause (Ellen et al., 2000).

It would also be useful to assess the importance of fit to the actual purchase of brands or future donations to the cause. More specifically, future research should examine whether the consumer's affinity for the cause affects the relationship between fit and purchase behavior. Recent findings indicate that when attitudes toward the cause are relatively low, fit might play a larger role in evaluating the partnership and the brand (Barone et al., 2007).

The advertising setting employed in this study could also present some problems. A much broader set of communications are typically involved in conveying the relationship between the brand and the cause (including internet advertising, press releases, etc.). As a result, the sub-dimensions identified could be too narrow. Finally, another limitation is the potential for respondent fatigue in completing the questionnaire. Because the survey instrument was long, we attempted to compensate by not placing any time constraints on our respondents, thereby allowing them to conduct the survey at their own pace.

Studies examining our results with different samples and in different settings are certainly another appropriate direction for future research. They could provide additional information about the sub-dimensions of fit analyzed in this study and others that did not emerge in our study. It is also possible that there are interactions between the different sub-dimensions of fit. Future research should explore these possibilities, both theoretically and empirically.

Despite these limitations, our research has advanced our understanding of the fit construct and its role in the context of cause-related marketing. The empirical examination identified ten "micro" and two "macro" sub-dimensions of fit and their effect on sponsorship and brand attitudes. By taking these into account, marketing managers can alleviate some of the uncertainty that has plagued many firms' efforts to create cause-marketing relationships viewed as favorable by the firm's consumers, beneficial to the firms' overall performance, and conducive to building stronger brands.

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